

Oncorhynchus nerka

Sockeye salmon



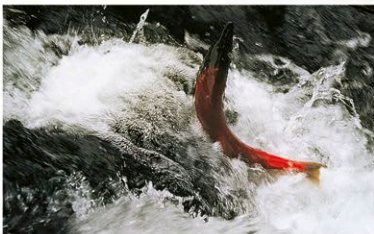
Length Up to 33 in (84 cm)
Weight Up to 15 lb (7 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location N.E. Asia, North Pacific, N.W. and W. North America



Also known as the “blueback” and the “red” salmon, the sockeye salmon undergoes a remarkable physical transformation at the time of spawning. Before spawning, sockeye salmon of both sexes have steel-blue heads and backs and silvery sides. However, between June and September or so, when they leave the ocean and enter

their natal spawning rivers, their heads turn bottle-green and their bodies bright red. Of all Pacific salmon, the sockeye salmon is unique because while in some populations the fry migrate straight down to the sea, most spend their first 1-2 years in lakes within their river’s watershed. The lake-locked form of sockeye salmon—the kokanee—is typically one-sixth the weight of its sea-going kin.



JUMPING THE RAPIDS
The sockeye salmon’s determination to reach its native spawning ground is demonstrated by the dramatic way it launches itself over rapids.



DISTINGUISHING FEATURES
The sockeye salmon has a streamlined body and a blunt, conical snout. It is distinguished from other salmon species by its fins, which usually lack definite spots, and its dramatic color change at spawning.



CRIMSON TIDE
The spectacular annual run of the sockeye salmon—sometimes comprising millions of fishes—is a popular attraction, with viewing platforms being built across spawning rivers.

SPAWNING

When they reach about 4 years old, all adult sockeye salmon eventually return to their native streams to spawn and then die—a final journey that can involve traveling up to 930 miles (1,500 km).



SMALL FRY
When sockeye salmon fry emerge from the gravel, they embark on their first journey to a nearby lake. They will stay there for at least a year before heading out to sea.

NEW LIFE
Having reached its spawning ground, the female sockeye salmon digs a nest in the gravel river bed and lays up to 4,300 bright pink eggs, which are fertilized by the male.



RIVER GRAVEYARD
After spawning, all sockeye salmon die, their bodies littering the same stretch of river in which they themselves were spawned.

RETURNING SOCKEYE SALMON
The sockeye salmon is anadromous—living in the sea but entering freshwater systems to spawn. As the salmon return to their spawning rivers, the bodies of both males and females turn red and their heads turn green; the male also develops a humped back and a hooked nose.